

# Croc Tears: The Good Kind

## Croctober 2026

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Hi, I'm Madhu Damani, MSBA candidate at the University of Minnesota. My idea is called Croc Tears — a digital-first Croctober campaign that flips a 600-year-old idiom on its head. Crocodile tears mean fake feelings. Croc tears? Those are the real ones. The happy ones. The overwhelming, catch-you-off-guard, can't-believe-this-is-my-life kind. This campaign turns those moments into a global, collective art piece — no new product required, just 23,000 real human feelings building one shoe together.

# CROC TEARS : Crocodile Tears are fake. Yours are the good happy kind.

"Crocodile tears" is a phrase every culture knows. It means fake emotion. But Crocs – the brand – has spent a decade proving that comfort lets people be real. The campaign reclaims the phrase: Croc tears aren't fake. They're the tears you cry when you're comfortable enough to feel. They are the tears that you cry when you are happy.

A digital-first activation where fans answer one question: "What gives you the good happy kind of tears?" Each answer becomes a dot. 23,000 dots, over 22 days, collectively reveal a hidden Crocs Classic Clog or Special Edition Croc on a global microsite. The croc doesn't exist until the fans build it - one feeling at a time.

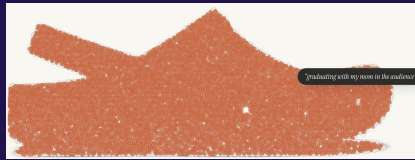
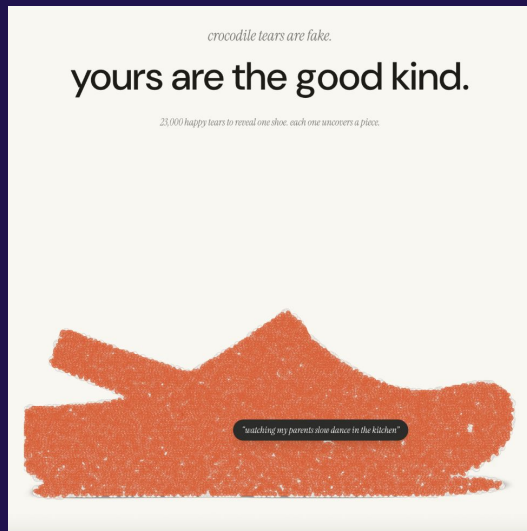
This isn't about selling just another croc. It's about proving what Crocs has always said: everyone should be comfortable in their own shoes. Not just physical comfort you wear, but emotional comfort you feel like the warmth of being completely, genuinely happy.

The core idea starts with a cultural insight that only Crocs can own. The phrase "crocodile tears" has existed since the 14th century - it means fake emotion. But Crocs, the brand, literally has the word "croc" in its name. No other brand can make this move. We flip the idiom: crocodile tears are fake, but Croc tears are the good kind - the happy, proud, overwhelmed-with-love kind. The activation is simple: fans visit a microsite and answer "what gives you the good kind of tears?" Each submission becomes one dot on a giant hidden shoe image. Over 22 days, 23,000 dots reveal a Crocs Classic Clog - the shoe only becomes visible because real people shared real feelings. It maps directly to the Wonderfully Unordinary platform - instinct over perfection, authenticity over performance. And it addresses the brief head-on: comfort you feel, not just comfort you wear. No new product. No inventory risk. Pure emotion, community, and culture.

# How it Comes to Life : PHASE 1

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Closer look of the masked croc

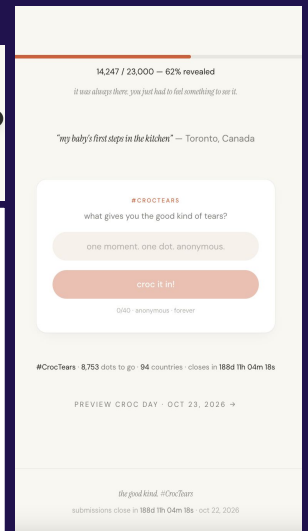
User Interface for croc-ing the answer



A microsite at [crocs.com/croctears](https://crocs.com/croctears) launches with a real Croc hidden behind 23,000 opaque dots.

Fans submit their "good kind of tears" moment; each answer removes one dot, revealing a piece of the croc underneath. Submissions are anonymous, capped at 40 characters, and tagged by country.

The croc gradually becomes visible as more people participate — like scratching a lottery ticket.



A progress bar tracks progress: "14,247 / 23,000 — 62% croc revealed". Live ticker shows submissions flowing in from the world in real time.

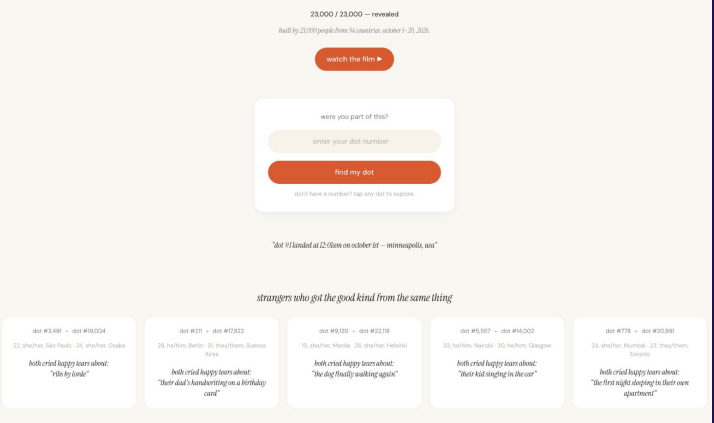
This is the core digital experience. On October 1st, a microsite goes live at [crocs.com/croctears](https://crocs.com/croctears). The hero visual is a real Crocs product image - but it's completely hidden behind 23,000 small opaque dots. You can't see the shoe at all on Day 1. Fans visit and answer one question: "what gives you the good kind of tears?" They type a short moment - 40 characters max, anonymous, tagged by country. When they submit, one dot disappears, revealing a tiny piece of the real shoe underneath. The more people participate, the more visible the Croc becomes - like scratching a lottery ticket collectively as a global community. A progress bar tracks where we are: "14,247 of 23,000 - 62% croc revealed." A live ticker scrolls real submissions from around the world in real time, creating a sense of global momentum. The key insight here is that the shoe doesn't exist without the fans. It only becomes visible because real people shared real feelings. That's the Crocs brand philosophy made literal - the community builds the brand. Note: the prototype countdown currently shows 188 days because it was built in April. In production, it would count down to October 22nd when submissions close.



## PHASE 2 : THE BIG REVEAL

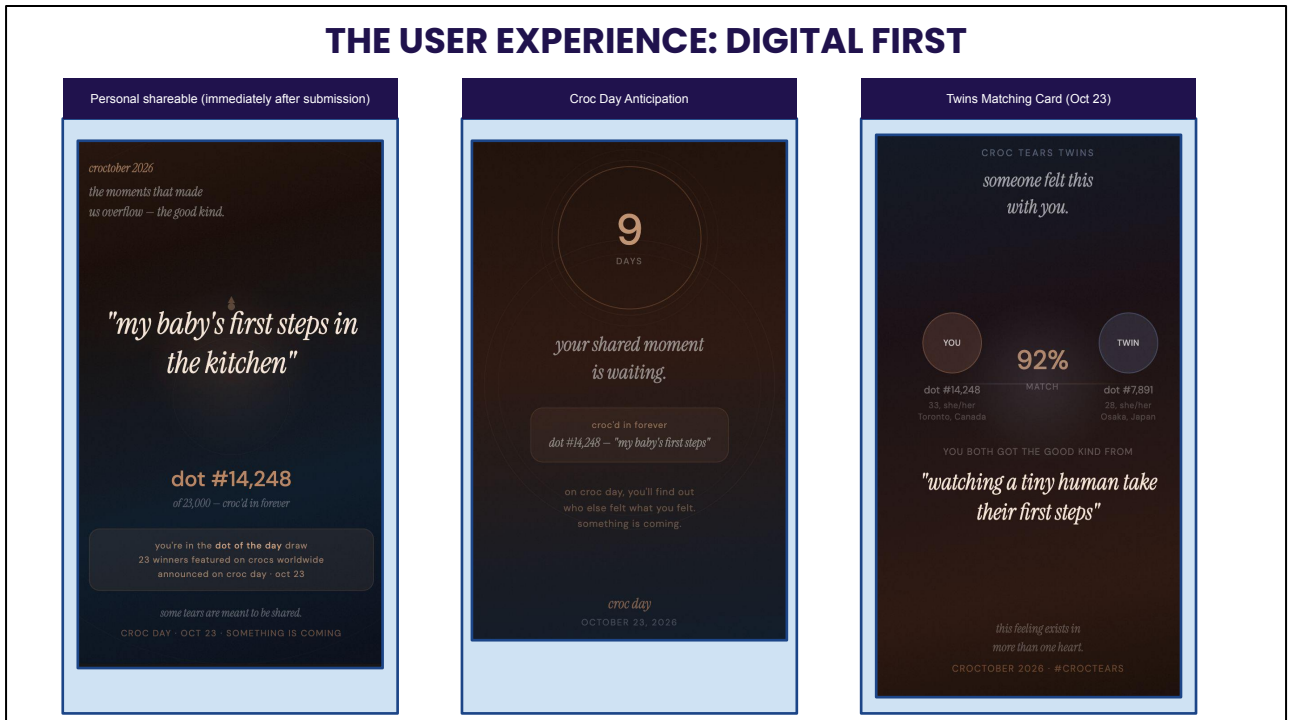
The fully revealed shoe is the hero - perfectly visible, made possible by 23,000 strangers. The shoe/croc is not fixed; It can be a rare edition, collaboration, or new silhouette. Users don't just browse - they unknowingly participate in the reveal. The platform turns into a living launch system. Behind the campaign, Crocs team along with analytics will finalise the crocs they wish to launch with this, it's chosen by Crocs' team based on what they have planned for 2026 Croctober.

1. Every participant can search their dot number and see exactly where their moment lives on the completed croc. A permanent archive lives at [crocs.com/croctears](https://crocs.com/croctears) - your dot is there forever
2. Matching algorithm pairs strangers from different countries who submitted similar moments. Every match = a new shareable card = a second viral wave after Croc Day.
3. A 3-minute hero film drops built entirely from real raw answers, no voiceover.



October 23 is where everything pays off. The crocs is fully revealed. The hero line shifts from "yours are the good kind" to "23,000 happy tears. one shoe. yours." Crocs drops a short film that's just submissions appearing on screen - no voiceover, no narration, just real moments from real people, set to a quiet ambient track. That film is designed to be the kind of content that stops you mid-scroll. The strategic unlock is that the shoe being revealed can change every year. The community doesn't know what shoe they're building until it's done. Crocs' analytics and merchandising teams choose the silhouette that benefits most from a cultural reveal moment heading into holiday. So this activation does double duty - it's a fan celebration and a product launch. After the reveal, the twins matching goes live. Every participant can discover a stranger from another country who felt the same thing. That twins card is the second viral wave - it extends the campaign's life by another week as people share their matches. The stats section anchors the scale: 23,000 tears, 94 countries, 20 days, one shoe. Here is the display of this prototype (its set to public for everyone to view) - [https://drive.google.com/file/d/1GC1YKDVk5amTDBSyTy-CloBqQ7qBDhKG/view?usp=drive\\_link](https://drive.google.com/file/d/1GC1YKDVk5amTDBSyTy-CloBqQ7qBDhKG/view?usp=drive_link)

## THE USER EXPERIENCE: DIGITAL FIRST



The user experience is built around three shareable moments - each one designed to drive a new cycle of awareness. The first is the personal card, generated immediately after submission. It shows the user's moment, their dot number, and the phrase "croc'd in forever" - confirming their contribution is permanent. It also mentions the dot of the day draw, where 23 winners across the campaign get featured on Crocs' global social channels. This card is formatted for Instagram Stories and TikTok - it's designed to be shared the second you get it. The second card is building anticipation for Croc Day. It confirms your dot is safe and teases the twins reveal: "on croc day, you'll find out who else felt what you felt. This drives return traffic to the site. The third card is the twins matching, revealed on Oct 23. You discover a stranger from another country who submitted something similar. It shows a percentage match and both submissions side by side. This is the second viral wave - everyone wants to see who their twin is and share it. For the primary audience of super fans, this gives them something deeper and more personal to share than a product photo. For the secondary audience of 18-24 women, the format is native to their behavior - anonymous submission, aesthetic card, matching mechanic designed to share their guilty pleasure, happy dark moments or whatever which they havent told with identity. A single most shared digital experience in the world. No app download, no sign-up, no purchase required. Type one sentence, get a beautiful card, share it. That's the whole funnel.

# WHY CROCS

The name is the idea.

No other brand on earth has "croc" in its name. The idiom "crocodile tears" is a cultural asset hiding in plain sight. This campaign claims it permanently.

Comfort you feel, not just comfort you wear.

The brief asked for emotional comfort. This delivers it - the shoe isn't the product of this campaign. The feeling is.

The fans build the shoe.

Every past Croctober gave fans a product. This one gives fans a verb. "I croc'd in." along with a product. The shoe only exists because they showed up. That's the most Crocs thing possible.

Three reasons this only works for Crocs. First, the name. No competitor can steal the phrase "Croc tears" - it's literally built from the brand name. This campaign takes a cultural phrase that's existed for 600 years and permanently attaches it to Crocs. Second, it answers the brief directly. The brief asked for comfort you feel, not comfort you wear. This campaign has almost no product on screen until the final reveal. The entire experience is about emotional comfort - the feeling of being honest about what moves you. Third, the fans build the shoe. Every past Croctober anchored on a hero product - the Cowboy Boot, the Pet Crocs, the Leopard Boot. This year, the activation is the hero. The shoe doesn't exist without the fans. That inverts the usual brand-fan relationship in a way that's authentically Crocs - a brand that was built by its community, not the other way around.

# THANKS!



This visual shows a high-impact experiential marketing installation outside the Crocs flagship store in SoHo, New York City. The core idea is to blur the line between retail, art, and digital storytelling. At street level, a massive 8-foot Crocs Classic Clog sculpture anchors the scene, immediately creating physical scale and curiosity. It is intentionally exaggerated and hyper-real, turning a familiar product into a landmark object.

Behind it, the LED storefront screen extends the narrative into a live digital experience. It displays a “Croc Tears” campaign microsite, where the product is not fully revealed yet. Instead, the shoe is gradually emerging through a pixel/dissolve effect, paired with a real-time progress bar showing collective participation—“14,247 / 23,000 — 62% revealed.” This introduces a gamified, community-driven unlock mechanism, where consumers indirectly influence product revelation. The copy, “crocodile tears are fake. yours are the good kind,” positions emotion as authentic and human, reinforcing Crocs’ broader comfort and self-expression positioning rather than functional footwear messaging.

Pedestrians engaging with the installation stopping, photographing, and recording signal a key objective: turning everyday foot traffic into organic media amplification. The experience is designed for social sharing first, not just in-store conversion.